The video was shot by me. Killing time before our flight, messing around, I panned the group, gave a running commentary on each lad, and when I came to my fellow cadet and good friend Ahmed Raza Kahn, a Pakistani, I said: *Ah, our little Paki friend…*

I didn't know that Paki was a slur. Growing up, I'd heard many people use that word and never saw anyone flinch or cringe, never suspected them of being racist. Neither did I know anything about unconscious bias. I was twenty-one, awash in isolation and privilege, and if I thought anything about this word at all, I thought it was like Aussie. Harmless.

I'd sent the footage to a fellow cadet, who was making an end-of-year video. Since then, it had circulated, flitted from computer to computer, and ultimately ended up in the hands of someone who sold it to the *News of the World*.

Heated condemnations began rolling in.

I'd learned nothing, people said.

I'd not matured one bit after the Nazi debacle, people said.

Prince Harry is worse than a thicko, they said, worse than a party boy—he's a racist.

The Tory leader denounced me. A cabinet minister went on TV to flog me. Ahmed's uncle condemned me to the BBC.

I was sitting in Highgrove, watching this furor rain down, barely able to process it.

My father's office issued an apology on my behalf. I wanted to issue one as well, but courtiers advised against it.

Not the best strategy, sir.

To hell with strategy. I didn't care about strategy. I cared about people not thinking I was a racist. I cared about *not being* a racist.

Above all, I cared about Ahmed. I connected with him directly, apologized. He said he knew I wasn't a racist. No big deal.

But it was. And his forgiveness, his easy grace, only made me feel worse.